ગુજરાતી શિક્ષણ સંધ

Consortium of Gujarati Schools

https://www.gujaratischools.org/

Biennial General Meeting

Sunday 19 May 2024 at 2.30 pm

Biennial Report for 2022-2024

Namaste everyone,

The last BGM of Consortium of Gujarati Schools was held on 22nd May 2022.The Rules were amended to include a new post for Vice Chair. In addition, in order to provide continuity, Chair and Secretary of the outgoing committee were also added to the incoming committee.

The Executive Committee was elected with Sonalben Shah as Chair and Tusharbhai Shah as Vice-Chair, Vijyaben Bhanderi as Secretary and Rekhaben Patel as Treasurer. Jayantbhai Tanna remained on the committee as Immediate Past Chair. In addition, 3 committee members were elected. These were Hasvinaben Shah, Rekhaben L Shah (Mandhata) and Prafulaben Shah. Further nominations were received at the meeting from Radhaben Patel, Riddhiben Patel, Jatinbhai Shah and Veljibhai Vekaria who were also elected.

The Executive Committee at their meeting co-opted three more members; Shobhaben Shah, Deepaben Chhatralia and Ritaben Kamdar.

Committee meetings

CGS organised Zoom committee meetings on 6th June 2023, 4th July 2023, 31st August 2023 and 28th September 2023. One meeting was scheduled in November 2023 but had to be cancelled.

It was suggested at the first meeting that it was important for committee members meet on a regular basis. As some Gujarati organisations were not aware of CGS's existence, it was suggested that efforts should also be made to make them familiar with our work. It was also suggested that CGS committee members should visit Gujarati schools to create a link with them and promote discussion about school issues and share good teaching practice. In addition, it was agreed to organise teachers' meetings for their feedback and to look at strategies to improve the number of children learning Gujarati.

School Information forms

'School Information Forms' were sent out in September 2022 and in September 2023 with follow-up reminders to all schools and organisations. We wished to collect information about the number of pupils in our Gujarati schools and number of candidates expected to sit for GCSE and A Level examinations for summer 2023 and 2024 GCSE Gujarati examinations.

However, we did not have much success in getting the information. We received only two replies – Sahajanand School in East London and Alperton Community School. This is a sad reflection of the commitment and leadership of our members, which we need to address!

CGS Membership

We received completed forms for 13 Individual memberships (£10) and 9 Organisational memberships (£25) as listed below.

Individual Members

1. Jayantbhai Tanna
2. Sonalben Shah
3. Rekhaben L Shah
4. Hasvinaben Shah
5. Vijyaben Bhanderi
6. Rajeshabhai Shah
7. Vibhaben Rawal
8. Rekhaben Patel
9. Radhaben Patel
10. Illaben Majithia
11. Kanchan R Shah
12. Sarlaben Shah
13. Kantaben Shah

Organisational Members

1. Shree Kutch Swaminarayan Satsang Temple, Gujarati School, Willesden
2. Mandhata Youth and Community Association
3. Shree Kutchi Leva Patel Community (UK), Saturday School
4. Shishukunj - Kenton Kendra
5. Shishukunj - Mill Hill Kendra
6. Oshwal Association of the UK, North Area Gujarati School
7. Oshwal Association of the UK, Northwest Area Gujarati School
8. Shree Muktajeevan Swamibapa Academy of Excellence, Swamibapa Gujarati School, Kingsbury
9. Alperton Community School - Upper School (Mainstream school)

GCSE candidates for Summer 2023

Fifty candidates sat for the Foundation Tier and 380 sat for the Higher-level exams making a total of 430. This was a slight increase on 2022 and 2021. Alperton Community School is now the only mainstream school that runs Gujarati courses in Gujarati although even their numbers have dropped. Entries for A level have dropped considerably and only four candidates sat for A level exams.

Sonalben stressed that we needed to improve standards at GCSE to raise the number of Gujarati learners opting to take Gujarati at A Level. She expressed concern about the quality of Speaking test examiners who lacked the ability to get the most out of their candidates' oracy skills. It was suggested that CGS should organise training for Speaking tests.

Training for teachers

Proposals for training included learning through games for Primary children; using project work to increase vocabulary, GCSE speaking tests, Curriculum organisation and other needs of member schools. However, it was suggested to organise a general meeting of teachers and headteachers to discuss their needs and requirements first.

A levels

The entry for candidates who sat for Gujarati A level in 2023 was the lowest as compared to other lesser taught languages. We therefore wanted to focus on A Level support this year. At the request of Jayantbhai, Trustees at Kenton Mandir granted permission to use computer room for A level classes at no charge. It was planned that CGS would conduct Gujarati A level support sessions for teacher candidates and help them with examination entry fees.

A letter regarding the A Level support sessions, together with the application form and details, were sent out on 23rd September 2023. However, we did not receive any response from any of our teachers or organisations. Only two private applications were received and one dropped out! Sonalben Shah gracefully accepted the challenge and tutored the remaining student. But it was very sad to see the lack of any enthusiasm from our school fraternity.

NCGO

Jayantbhai attended NCGO AGM on Sunday 9th July 2023 and had an opportunity to talk about CGS and its achievements since its conception. He raised the issues CGS was facing especially regarding funding, accommodation and resources.

Those present were impressed about the work of CGS. One of the NCGO Committee members Shri Jayrajbhai Bhadranwala pledged to donate £500 individually for CGS work! CB Patel also requested the new committee to co-opt Jayantbhai Tanna and support CGS Gujarati teaching and learning. CGS was invited to attend NCGO committee meeting on 1st October 2023. Tusharbhai and Sonalben attended the meeting. Tusharbhai briefed them on the CGS background details and the work done so far. Sonalben explained that the teachers are not trained and lack the knowledge of the UK education system. CGS supported Gujarati teachers and community organisations by providing training. Sonalben also explained that donations received would be used to fund the A level candidates exam fees in order to attract more people to take A Level Gujarati. NCGO could help by promoting CGS's work in their newsletters and by promoting Gujarati language at their events and functions, especially for a new influx of young Indian Gujaratis who are keen to retain our culture and language. NCGO have included brief account of CGS in their Newsletters. A suggestion about the India High Commission helping to support an exchange programme for Gujarati students in UK and Gujarat was also mentioned.

Finally….

In addition, there are many parents and also established organisations which are not sufficiently aware of or are keen on supporting the learning of Gujarati for our children.

We therefore urge all Gujarati parents, students, teachers, trainers, community organisers and Trustees as well as Gujarati newspapers, radio and TV presenters, opinion formers and Gujarati experts and writers to work tirelessly to save our Gujarati Bhasha – our future. We at the CGS are committed to do so. Please join us.

Appreciation and Thanks

I would like to thank all the committee members and all our teachers and leaders who have worked so hard and supported us during the last 2 years.

I wish the incoming Chair the very best and offer my full support.

Finally, a very big THANK YOU to all of you who have sacrificed your precious time and made the effort to attend this important meeting!

Sonalben Shah
Chair
Consortium of Gujarati schools